dominance as well. For Babur clearly states that Mahmud Mirza's love for beardless youths was not checked by any social taboos and even extended to his own family.'[71]

For Akbar, too, homosexuality amongst the men in his court, particularly the more powerful men in his court, may not have breached religious or social prohibitions as much as it posed a political threat. Such a man might well nurse the idea of taking Akbar into his bed as a way of taking over Akbar's throne – on which, some might say, Bairam Khan was already keeping a chaste but too possessive eye.

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The fourth year of Akbar's reign – March 1559 to March 1560 – may have broken Ali Quli's heart, but it brought him some poetic justice, too. Pir Muhammad, the man who killed Hemu's aged father and Ali Quli's envoy, was exiled.

Bairam's deputy had been outgrowing his boots for a while. He had joined Bairam's retinue as an impoverished mullah, and risen rapidly so that he held the reins of all 'political and financial affairs' by this time.[72] It was to him, writes Nizamuddin, that 'the nobles and officers had to make their applications', and it's clear these applications enriched the mullah's treasury as much as they inflated his ego. Once, for example, when offering Bairam Khan an impromptu snack during a hunt – 'whatever may be at hand', he said, coyly – Pir Muhammad produced '3000 drinking cups and 700 porcelain dishes'.[73]

Pir Muhammad was not only corrupt, he was bloodthirsty, too, and frighteningly flippant about taking human life. Once, to decide whether Bairam Khan should or shouldn't kill yet another of his enemies in court, the mullah proposed a gruesome little game. Pir Muhammad took two pieces of paper, one inscribed 'Release', the other 'Death'. The chits were drawn up and thrown in the air; Death landed face up. The courtier lost his life.

Thus, the mullah's wealth and power grew unchecked. '[O]f the many, high and low, who attended at his door,' Nizamuddin continues, 'he admitted hardly anyone.' One day, however, he went too far. Pir Muhammad was too unwell – or, according to Nizamuddin, too arrogant –